

DON'T DIE RETIRED

Tech Confident

The scam-proof guide to your phone, your apps and your online life

Guide + 4-week plan · £9

dontdieretired.com

This guide is general information about using your phone and online services safely, not professional advice. App and settings names change with updates, so menus may differ slightly on your device. If you think you have been scammed, contact your bank immediately and report it — in the UK to Report Fraud (formerly Action Fraud) at reportfraud.police.uk or 0300 123 2040, or dial 159 to reach your bank; in the US to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.

Tech Confident

The scam-proof guide to your phone, your apps and your online life. Not a course in becoming a computer expert. A plain, unhurried guide to setting your phone up so it works for you, keeping your money and your accounts safe, and getting the good things — the video calls, the photos, the maps, the library books — without the worry.

Most people over 50 are not 'bad with technology'. They are simply using devices that were designed by and for people who grew up with them, with settings hidden three menus deep and a steady drip of messages designed to frighten them. This guide fixes both. By the end of it you will have a phone set up the way you want it, a handful of habits that make you a very hard target for scammers, and the confidence to try new things because you know what to do if something goes wrong.

Tech Confident is built around one idea: **confidence comes from knowing the few things that matter, not from knowing everything**. You do not need to understand how your phone works. You need to know where the text-size setting is, how to spot a scam message in five seconds, and who to ring if you ever get caught out. That is a short list. This guide covers it, then gives you a four-week plan of fifteen-minute tasks to make it stick.

How to use this guide

Read Parts 1 to 3 first, with your phone beside you (about an hour, with pauses to try things).

Do the 'Settings to change today' checklist in Part 1 before anything else.

Keep the 'Scam red flags' table and the 'Who to call' table somewhere you can find them — print them or photograph them.

Then follow the 4-week plan one day at a time. Fifteen minutes a day. No homework.

A note on menus: phones update themselves, and every update moves a setting or renames a menu. Where this guide says 'Settings then Display', your phone may say 'Settings then Screen'. If you cannot find something, use the search box at the top of the Settings app: type the word you are after ('text size', 'emergency') and it will take you there.

Part 1: Set your phone up for you

Your phone arrived set up for an imaginary average person with perfect eyesight and small thumbs. Twenty minutes of changes make it yours. Everything in this part is in the Settings app — the grey cog icon — on both iPhone and Android phones. The two systems put things in slightly different places, so both are given.

Make it readable: text size and display

The single most useful change most people never make. Larger text turns squinting into reading and makes every app easier, not just the ones you expected.

- **iPhone:** Settings, then Accessibility, then Display & Text Size, then Larger Text. Slide the bar to the right until it is comfortable. You can also turn on Bold Text here, which helps more than you would think.
- **Android:** Settings, then Display, then Font size (or Display size and text on some phones). Drag the slider. Many Android phones also have a 'Bold text' switch nearby. Menu names vary by manufacturer — Samsung, Google and others each have their own wording, but 'Display' is the place to start.
- **Both:** while you are there, look for 'Zoom' or 'Magnification'. Turning it on lets you enlarge any part of the screen with a gesture (usually a triple tap) — useful for small print in an email or on a map.
- **Screen brightness and 'auto-brightness'** live in the same Display menu. If the screen is hard to read outdoors, turn brightness up; if it is glaring in bed, turn on the night or 'warm' mode.

Hearing and vision accessibility

The Accessibility menu (Settings, then Accessibility, on both systems) is one of the best-kept secrets on any phone. It was built for people with disabilities and it is useful to almost everyone over 50.

- **Hearing:** both systems can pair with hearing aids directly (look for 'Hearing devices' or 'Hearing aids'). Both can show live captions on calls and videos ('Live Captions' on iPhone, 'Live Caption' on Android). Both can flash the torch (flashlight) when a call comes in, and both let you turn the ringer and alert volume up separately from the media volume.
- **Vision:** both can read the screen aloud (VoiceOver on iPhone, TalkBack on Android — these are powerful but take practice; start with 'Spoken Content' or 'Select to Speak', which just reads out what you select). Both have high-contrast and colour-filter options, and both let you make the pointer or cursor larger.
- **Hands:** if tapping is tricky, look for 'Touch accommodations' or 'Touch and hold delay' — they make the phone more forgiving of tremor or a slow tap. 'AssistiveTouch' (iPhone) and 'Accessibility Menu' (Android) put common actions behind one big on-screen button.
- **Motion:** if animations make you feel queasy, 'Reduce Motion' turns them off.

Emergency contacts and medical information

Both systems let you store the name of someone to call in an emergency, plus medical details, so that a paramedic or a passer-by can see them from the lock screen without your passcode. Set it up once and forget it. It takes five minutes and could matter more than anything else in this guide.

- **iPhone:** open the Health app, tap your profile picture (top right), then Medical ID. Add your emergency contacts and, if you wish, medications, allergies and conditions. Turn on **Show When Locked**. Apple's support pages also describe 'Share During Emergency Call', which sends your

Medical ID to emergency services when you call from the phone (this works in some countries and not others).

- **Android:** Settings, then Safety & emergency (on Samsung: Safety and emergency; on some phones it is under 'About phone', then 'Emergency information'). Add emergency contacts and medical information. There is usually a switch to show this on the lock screen.
- **Emergency SOS:** both systems can call the emergency number by pressing the side or power button several times. Find the setting (search 'Emergency SOS' or 'Emergency SOS' in Settings) and check whether it is on and how it is triggered, so you neither call 999 or 911 by accident nor discover it is off when you need it.

Find My: for the day you lose it

Every phone can be found, locked and, if necessary, wiped from another device or a web browser — but only if the feature is switched on beforehand. Do it now, while you are calm and the phone is in your hand.

- **iPhone:** Settings, tap your name at the top, then Find My, then Find My iPhone. Turn it on, and turn on 'Find My network' and 'Send Last Location' too. If you lose the phone, sign in at icloud.com/find on any computer, or use the Find My app on a family member's iPhone.
- **Android:** Google's 'Find My Device' (renamed 'Find Hub' on newer phones) needs the phone to be signed into your Google account with location on. Check it in Settings, then Google, then 'Find My Device' or 'Find Hub'. If you lose the phone, go to android.com/find on any browser and sign in. Google's help pages say you can then see the phone's location, lock it with your PIN, or erase it.
- **Either way:** write down your Apple ID or Google account email and make sure you know its password (Part 2 will help). Without them, Find My cannot help you.

Updates, and a lock on the front door

Software updates fix security holes that criminals actively use. They are the one nag from your phone worth obeying. Turn on automatic updates (Settings, then General, then Software Update on iPhone; Settings, then System, then Software update on most Android phones) and let it install overnight while charging. If your phone is so old that it no longer receives updates, that is worth knowing — it is the strongest argument for eventually replacing it.

A phone with no passcode is an open handbag. Set a six-digit passcode (not your birthday, not 123456) and turn on face or fingerprint unlock so you rarely have to type it. The passcode still matters — it is what protects you if the phone is lost — so pick something you can remember and nobody could guess.

Settings to change today

This is the checklist. Tick each one off with your phone in your hand.

- ☐ Text size increased until it is comfortable (and Bold Text on, if it helps)
- ☐ Emergency contacts and medical information added, and shown on the lock screen
- ☐ Emergency SOS checked: I know how it triggers
- ☐ Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device / Find Hub (Android) switched on
- ☐ I know the email address and password of my Apple ID or Google account
- ☐ Automatic software updates turned on
- ☐ A six-digit passcode set, with face or fingerprint unlock on top
- ☐ Hearing or vision features I need (captions, hearing aid pairing, magnifier) tried once

- ☐ Auto-brightness or night mode set so the screen is comfortable

Part 2: Passwords and the second lock

Passwords are where most people feel most defeated. Too many, too complicated, forgotten by Tuesday, written on a Post-it. The good news is that the official advice has changed to something much more humane, and the tools to make it painless are already on your phone.

Three random words

The UK's National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC — the government's cyber-security experts) now recommends making a password from **three random words**: something like 'kettle-Tuesday-giraffe'. Their reasoning is that this is long enough to be very hard for a computer to guess, and easy enough for a human to remember, which is the combination that matters. They advise against the things criminals can find on your social media: pet names, football teams, birthdays and children's names. You do not need a different memorable phrase for everything. You need one for your email account, one for the phone's Apple or Google account, and a way to handle the rest — which is what the next two sections are for.

The NCSC's first tip for staying secure online is to use a strong and separate password for your email. The reason is simple once you see it: almost every other account — your bank, your shopping, your social media — sends a 'reset your password' link to your email. Whoever controls your inbox can, in effect, take over everything else. So your email password should be unique, made of three random words, and shared with nothing else.

Let the phone remember the rest

A **password manager** is a locked notebook inside your phone that stores your passwords and types them in for you. The NCSC's guidance says a password manager 'stores passwords safely for you, meaning that you can have unique passwords for each service', and that using the one built into your browser or phone is safe on your own devices and 'the easiest way to remember your passwords'.

- **You already have one.** iPhones have a built-in manager (the Passwords app, or under Settings, then Passwords on older versions). Android phones and the Chrome browser use Google Password Manager (Settings, then Google, then Passwords, or passwords.google.com). Both will offer to save a password when you log in somewhere, suggest a strong one when you create an account, and fill it in next time.
- **Say yes when it offers.** The habit is simply: when the phone asks 'Save this password?', tap yes. When it offers a 'strong password' for a new account, accept it. You never need to see or remember that password again.
- **Separate apps exist** that work across an iPhone, a Windows laptop and everything else. The NCSC notes that their main advantage is synchronising passwords between devices. If you only use one phone, the built-in one is plenty.
- **Protect the manager itself.** It is only as safe as your phone's passcode and your Apple or Google account. The NCSC says to switch on two-step verification on the account that holds the manager — which brings us to the second lock.

Two-step verification: the second lock

Two-step verification — called 2SV, two-factor authentication, 2FA or 'multi-factor' depending on who is talking — means that logging in from a new device needs your password **and** something else: usually

a six-digit code sent to your phone by text, or shown in an app. The NCSC describes it as 'a way of double checking that you really are the person you are claiming to be'. If a criminal gets your password, they still cannot get in without your phone.

- **Do email first.** The NCSC says to prioritise your email, 'as criminals with access to your inbox can use it to reset passwords on your other accounts'. Then your Apple or Google account, then banking and anything with your card details.
- **Text-message codes are fine to start with.** The NCSC is candid that text messages 'are not the most secure type of 2SV, but still offer a huge advantage over not using any 2SV', and that any 2SV 'is better than not having it at all'.
- **Authenticator apps** (Google Authenticator and Microsoft Authenticator are two named by the NCSC) show a fresh code every thirty seconds and work without phone signal. They are a good second step once you are comfortable.
- **Backup codes.** When you turn 2SV on, most services offer a list of one-off backup codes. Print them or write them down and keep them with your important papers. They get you in if you lose your phone.
- **Where to find it:** the government's Stop! Think Fraud campaign notes it is 'usually found in the security settings of your account' and 'can be turned on in a matter of minutes'. Look for 'Security', then 'Two-step verification' or 'Two-factor authentication'.

The one rule about codes

A 2SV code is for you to type into a login screen. It is never for reading out to somebody on the phone. Your bank will never ring and ask for it. Nobody legitimate will. If anyone asks for a code you have just received, that is the scam, and the call ends there.

Part 3: Recognising scams

Scams are not clever. They are scripts, repeated millions of times, and they all lean on the same three levers: **urgency** (act now), **authority** (we are your bank, the police, HMRC, Microsoft) and **secrecy** (don't tell anyone, don't hang up). Once you can name the lever, the script stops working on you. This part walks through the common scripts, then puts the tell-tale signs in one table. Two things to hold onto before the details. First: **anyone can be scammed**. Age UK, the charity for older people, puts it exactly that way — being caught out is not a sign of foolishness, it is a sign of a good script. Second: the NCSC's summary of how to deal with any suspicious message is 'break the contact — don't reply, click on any links, call any phone numbers', then check through a route you already trust. Every scam below is beaten by that one move.

Phishing: the fake email or text

'Phishing', in the NCSC's definition, 'is when criminals use scam emails, text messages or phone calls to trick their victims'. The message pretends to be from a company or a government body you deal with — your bank, HMRC, the NHS, Amazon, Netflix — and asks you to click a link to 'verify your account', 'claim a refund', 'pay an outstanding fee' or 'confirm a delivery'. The link goes to a copy of the real website that collects whatever you type.

- **The giveaway is the ask.** Real organisations do not send a link and ask you to log in from it. If a message worries you, close it and go to the website or app the way you normally do — by typing the address, or opening the app — and check there.
- **Look at the sender,** not the name. On a phone, tap the sender's name to see the actual email address. 'Amazon' from a string of random letters at an address you have never seen is not Amazon.
- **Report it.** In the UK, forward suspicious emails to report@phishing.gov.uk (the NCSC investigates them) and forward suspicious texts to 7726 — it is free, and your mobile provider uses the reports to block senders. Both addresses come from the government's own reporting page.

The 'Hi Mum' message

A message, usually on WhatsApp but increasingly by ordinary text, from an unknown number: 'Hi Mum, I've broken my phone and I'm using a friend's old one — this is my new number.' Which?, the consumer organisation, quotes one real example almost word for word: 'Hello mum, I've broken my phone and I'm using a friends old one.' Once you reply, a story follows — a bill that must be paid today, a phone that cannot access banking — and a request to transfer money to an account that is not your child's, because 'my account is locked'. Which? recommends not transferring anything on the strength of the message. Instead: ask a question only your child could answer, ring the number you already have for them, or ask for a voice note. Age UK suggests agreeing a family 'safe word' in advance, and notes that criminals can now fake a family member's voice, so a safe word beats 'it sounded like her'. If money has already gone, contact your bank straight away. Which? adds that suspicious texts should be forwarded to 7726 before you block the number.

The parcel or courier text

'Your parcel could not be delivered — pay a small fee to rearrange.' The fee is tiny; the point is to get your card details and your address into a form the criminals control. Real delivery companies do not ask for redelivery fees by text link. If you are expecting a parcel, track it through the retailer's own website or app, never through the text.

The bank or police impersonation call

The most damaging script, because it is the most convincing. A caller says they are from your bank's fraud team (or the police, investigating your bank). There has been suspicious activity. To protect your money, you must move it to a 'safe account' — or read out your PIN, or hand your card to a courier who will collect it. Age UK's phone-scams page is blunt: 'Your bank would never do this', and 'The real police would never come to your house and ask for this information'. The caller ID on your screen proves nothing — Age UK notes that criminals can make it show a real bank's number.

Stop. Hang up. Call back on the number on your card.

This is the rule that beats bank impersonation every time. Whatever the caller says, however urgent, however real the number looks: stop, hang up, and ring your bank yourself on the number printed on the back of your card.

In the UK you can dial **159** instead. It is a short code run by Stop Scams UK that connects you straight to your own bank's fraud line — the organisation describes it as an easy route back to safety when you get an unexpected call about a financial matter, and says the number cannot be spoofed. More than 25 UK banks and building societies take part. Calls cost the same as a national-rate call from most providers.

If you can, use a different phone to call back, or wait a few minutes: some older phone lines can be held open by the caller.

The romance scam

Someone you met online — a dating site, a Facebook group, a game — becomes affectionate quickly, then finds reasons never to meet: the US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) lists 'living or traveling outside the country, working on an oil rig, in the military, or working with an international organization'. Eventually there is a crisis, and a request for money by a route that cannot be traced. The FTC's list of those routes is a checklist in itself: wire transfer, gift cards with the PIN codes read out, a money-transfer app, or cryptocurrency. The FTC's single rule: 'Never send money or gifts to a sweetheart you haven't met in person.' It also suggests a reverse image search on their photos (most search engines let you upload a picture and see where else it appears) and telling a friend or family member — people outside the situation spot the pattern faster.

The tech-support pop-up

You are browsing and the screen fills with a flashing warning: your computer is infected, call this number now. Or the phone rings and 'Microsoft' or 'Apple' or 'your broadband provider' has detected a virus. The FTC's two rules cut straight through it: 'Legitimate tech companies won't contact you by phone, email, or text message to tell you there's a problem with your computer', and 'Real security pop-up warnings and messages will never ask you to call a phone number.' The aim is to get you to let them control your computer remotely, and then to pay — again by gift card, wire or crypto. If a pop-up appears, do not call the number and do not click it. Close the browser (on a computer, if it will not close, hold the power button until it turns off). Then, the FTC suggests, update your security software and run a scan. If you did give someone remote access or a password, change that password and any account sharing it, and ring your bank if any card details were involved.

The pension or investment offer

A call, email or advert offering a free pension review, a guaranteed return, or a way to unlock your pension early. The Financial Conduct Authority (FCA — the UK's financial regulator) says of cold calls about pensions: 'the safest thing to do is hang up. It's illegal and probably a scam.' Its warning signs include a guaranteed better return, high-pressure sales tactics, unusual or unregulated investments, structures so complicated you cannot see where the money goes, and several firms all taking a fee. It adds plainly that 'Professional advice on pensions is not free.' Before dealing with any firm about money, check it is on the FCA's Financial Services Register (register.fca.org.uk) using the contact details on the register, not the ones the firm gave you. This is general information, not financial advice — a regulated adviser can look at your own situation. In the US the equivalent checks are with your state securities regulator and the SEC's [investor.gov](https://www.investor.gov).

Red flag	What it looks like	What to do instead
Urgency	'Act now', 'within 24 hours', 'your account will be closed', 'the courier is on his way'	Nothing genuine collapses if you take an hour. Put the phone down and check by a route you trust.
A link to log in	Email or text with a button to 'verify', 'confirm', 'claim' or 'pay'	Never log in from a link. Open the app or type the website address yourself.
A request for a code, PIN or password	'Read me the code we just sent', 'confirm your PIN for security'	Nobody legitimate asks for these. End the call.
Move money to a 'safe account'	Your bank's 'fraud team' needs you to transfer your savings to protect them	Banks never do this. Hang up; ring 159 (UK) or the number on your card.
Unusual payment method	Gift cards, vouchers, wire transfer, crypto, a money-transfer app to a stranger	No real bill, fee, fine or tax is paid in gift cards. Walk away.
Secrecy	'Don't tell your family', 'don't tell the bank staff what it's for'	Secrecy is the scam. Tell someone straight away.
New number, old relationship	'Hi Mum, new phone', a 'friend' messaging from an unknown account	Ring the number you already have. Use your safe word.
Too good to be true	Guaranteed returns, free pension review, prize you did not enter, refund you did not claim	It is. Check the FCA register (UK) or report to the FTC (US) before anything else.
A pop-up with a phone number	'Your device is infected — call Microsoft on...'	Real warnings never carry a phone number. Close the browser.
Pressure to keep the line open	'Stay on the phone while you do it', 'don't hang up'	Hang up. If possible use a different phone to call back.

Part 4: The good things

Video calling family

Video calling is, for many people, the best thing a phone does, and it is easier than it looks. iPhones have FaceTime built in (it only calls other Apple devices). WhatsApp works on both iPhone and Android and is the most common choice for families. Google Meet, Zoom and Microsoft Teams work on anything and are what clubs, doctors and adult-education classes tend to use. You do not need all of them: ask the people you call most what they use, and start with that.

- **Practise on a willing victim.** Ask a family member for a ten-minute test call at a quiet time. Learn where the mute button, the camera-flip button and the red hang-up button are. That is 90 per cent of it.
- **Prop the phone up.** A stand, a mug, a stack of books — anything so you are not holding it at arm's length for an hour. Face a window rather than sit with it behind you.
- **Wi-Fi, not mobile data.** Video calls use a lot of data. At home, make sure the phone is on your Wi-Fi (the fan-shaped symbol at the top of the screen) so it is not eating your allowance.
- **Group calls** — the whole family on one screen — work in all of these apps. Somebody 'starts' the call and invites the rest; you just need to tap 'Join' or answer.

Photos and backup

The photos on your phone are probably the most irreplaceable thing on it. A phone can be dropped, lost, stolen or simply die. **Backup** means a copy of your photos (and contacts, and messages) is kept automatically somewhere else — 'in the cloud', which just means on the phone-maker's computers — so a new phone can restore everything. The NCSC lists backing up as one of its core tips.

- **iPhone:** Settings, tap your name, then iCloud, then Photos: turn on 'Sync this iPhone' (older versions say 'iCloud Photos'). Check 'iCloud Backup' is on in the same menu. Apple gives a small amount of storage free; most people with a lot of photos end up paying a small monthly fee for more.
- **Android:** open the Google Photos app, tap your profile picture, then Photos settings, then Backup, and turn it on. Google also gives some free storage and sells more. Samsung phones can additionally back up to a Samsung account.
- **Check it is actually working.** Once a month, open the Photos settings and look for 'backup complete' or the last backup date. A backup that quietly stopped six months ago is the commonest unpleasant surprise.
- **Sharing photos** is built into every photos app: tap a picture, tap the share symbol (a box with an arrow, or three joined dots), pick WhatsApp, Messages or email. Shared albums let a family add to one collection.
- **Tidy occasionally.** Delete the blurry ones and the seventeen near-identical shots. A less cluttered library is easier to enjoy and cheaper to store.

Online banking, safely

Banking on your phone is, done properly, one of the safest ways to bank — the app knows it is you, it shows every transaction as it happens, and it is where you can freeze a card in seconds. The safety comes from a few habits, not from avoiding it.

- **Only the official app.** Download it from the App Store (iPhone) or Google Play (Android), or from a link on your bank's real website. Never from a link in a message.
- **Face, fingerprint and a strong passcode** on the app, plus 2SV on the account.

- **Check the app, not the message.** Any text or email 'from your bank' about a problem is checked by opening the app. If there is nothing there, there is nothing there.
- **Freeze first, ask later.** Most banking apps have a 'freeze card' or 'lock card' switch. If you think your card details have leaked, freeze it — you can unfreeze it in a minute if you were wrong.
- **Turn on notifications** for payments. A ping for every transaction feels fussy for a week, then becomes the earliest warning you will ever get.
- **Public Wi-Fi:** avoid banking on café or hotel Wi-Fi. Your phone's own mobile data is fine.
- **Never move money because someone rang you.** See Part 3. This is the whole of it.

Useful apps, by category

You do not need dozens of apps. You need one good one in each category you actually use. Brand names change and vary by country, so this table describes the category and mentions the built-in or best-known options only where it helps you find them. Search the App Store or Google Play by the category name and pick the one with the highest ratings and the most reviews.

What you want to do	Type of app	Notes
Find your way on foot, by car or on public transport	Maps / navigation	Apple Maps (iPhone) and Google Maps (both) are built in or free. Both give spoken turn-by-turn directions, show bus and train times, and can download an area for use without signal. Say the destination aloud rather than typing it.
Trains, buses, taxis	Transport	Rail operators, bus companies and city transport authorities each have an app that shows live times and sells tickets to your phone. Taxi and ride apps (Uber and its rivals) show the fare before you book and the car's number plate as it arrives.
Health records, prescriptions, appointments	Health / patient portal	In England, the NHS App (from the NHS itself) lets you order repeat prescriptions, book GP appointments, see your GP record and test results, and manage hospital referrals — NHS Digital lists all of these. Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland have their own routes. In the US, most health systems offer a 'patient portal' app (MyChart is the commonest) for the same jobs.
Reading and audiobooks for free	Library	Public libraries lend e-books and audiobooks through apps — Libby is widely used by UK and US libraries, and BorrowBox by many UK ones. You need only your library card number. Text size is adjustable, which many people find easier than print.
Messaging and video calls	Messaging	WhatsApp is the commonest for families in the UK; iMessage and FaceTime are built into iPhones; Signal is a privacy-focused alternative. Ask your family what they use.
Weather, news, radio	Information	The built-in weather app is usually enough. The BBC and NPR have free news and radio apps. Podcasts play through Apple Podcasts, Google's Podcasts within YouTube Music, Spotify, or the BBC Sounds app.
Paying for things	Wallet / payment	Apple Wallet and Google Wallet let you tap the phone instead of a card and store tickets and boarding passes. They are safe to use and do not reveal your card number to the shop.
Remembering things	Notes, reminders, calendar	All built in. The Reminders / Google Keep and Calendar apps can be set by voice ('remind me to take the bins out at 7') and shared with a partner.
Identifying a plant, a bird, a song	Recognition	Point the camera at it. Google Lens (Android, and inside the Google app on iPhone) and the iPhone's 'Visual Look Up' identify plants and landmarks; Merlin (from Cornell University)

What you want to do	Type of app	Notes
		identifies birdsong; Shazam names music.

Voice assistants

Siri (Apple), Google Assistant or Gemini (Android) and Alexa (Amazon's speakers) all do the same handful of things well: set timers and alarms, answer simple questions, make calls, send messages, play music and the radio, and control smart lights or heating if you have them. For anyone with tired eyes or unsteady hands, 'Hey Siri, ring Margaret' is easier than any screen.

- **Turn on the wake word** in Settings (search 'Siri' or 'Assistant') so you can speak to the phone without touching it.
- **Speak normally.** 'What's the weather tomorrow?', 'Set a timer for twelve minutes', 'Text Dave: running ten minutes late'. It will read back what it heard before sending a message.
- **Privacy:** assistants listen for the wake word and send what you say after it to the company's servers. Both Apple and Google let you review and delete these recordings in Settings. If that bothers you, the mute switch on a smart speaker is a physical switch and works.
- **They are not oracles.** Assistants can be confidently wrong, especially the newer AI-based ones. Use them for timers and calls, and check anything important elsewhere.

Part 5: When something goes wrong

Something will, eventually — a lost phone, a clicked link, a moment on a bad day when a caller sounded right. The difference between a nuisance and a disaster is almost entirely how fast you act in the first hour, and knowing who to ring. So this part is short, and worth photographing.

If you think you have been scammed

1. **Contact your bank immediately.** Age UK's first instruction, and the one that matters most: the sooner the bank knows, the more chance of stopping or recovering a payment. Use the number on your card, or 159 in the UK. Ask them to freeze the card or account if needed. Age UK notes that you 'may be able to recover money you've lost in unauthorised or unexpected payments', though it is not guaranteed.
2. **Change the passwords** of any account involved — starting with your email — and turn on 2SV if it was off. If you used the same password anywhere else, change it there too.
3. **If you gave someone remote access** to a computer, switch it off and do not use it for banking until someone you trust has checked it. Run the security software.
4. **Report it.** In England, Wales and Northern Ireland, report to Report Fraud (the national reporting centre formerly known as Action Fraud) at reportfraud.police.uk or on 0300 123 2040, open 24 hours. In Scotland, report to Police Scotland on 101. In the US, report at ReportFraud.ftc.gov (the FTC's online form — during a US government shutdown the site can be temporarily unavailable). Reporting matters even if you lost nothing: it is how patterns get spotted and websites taken down.
5. **Tell someone.** Age UK says scams can leave people 'feeling embarrassed, unsettled and unsafe', and that 'anyone can be scammed'. Ring a friend, a family member, or one of the helplines below. You are not the first, and you did nothing stupid.

If you have lost your phone

1. **Find it or lock it** from another device: icloud.com/find (iPhone) or android.com/find (Android). Both let you make it ring, show a message on the screen, lock it, or erase it.
2. **Ring your mobile provider** to block the SIM so nobody can run up calls or receive your 2SV codes.
3. **Tell your bank** if the banking app was on it (it is protected by your face or passcode, but they can add a watch).
4. **Change your Apple or Google account password** from another device, which signs the lost phone out of everything.
5. **When you get a new phone**, the backup from Part 4 restores your photos, contacts and apps. This is the moment you will be glad you checked it.

The 'who to call' table

Situation	United Kingdom	United States
I think a caller is pretending to be my bank	Hang up. Dial 159, or ring the number on the back of your card	Hang up. Ring the number on the back of your card
I have lost money to a scam	Your bank first (159 or your card). Then Report Fraud: reportfraud.police.uk or 0300 123 2040 (24 hours). Scotland: Police Scotland, 101	Your bank or card issuer first. Then the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov
I got a suspicious email	Forward it to report@phishing.gov.uk	Forward it to reportphishing@apwg.org (the address the FTC gives) or report at

Situation	United Kingdom	United States
		ReportFraud.ftc.gov
I got a suspicious text	Forward it to 7726 (free)	Forward it to 7726 (spells SPAM on the keypad) — the FTC gives the same number
A pension or investment offer looks wrong	FCA consumer helpline 0800 111 6768; check register.fca.org.uk	Your state securities regulator; investor.gov
I want to talk it through with someone kind	Age UK Advice Line 0800 678 1602, 8am to 7pm, 365 days a year	AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline 877-908-3360, Monday to Friday, 8am to 8pm Eastern — free, and open to non-members
Someone is in immediate danger or a crime is happening now	999	911

Numbers change

These contacts were checked against the organisations' own websites when this guide was written. Organisations rename themselves (Action Fraud became Report Fraud) and numbers move. If one does not work, search for the organisation by name and take the contact details from its own website — never from a message someone sent you.

Part 6: Helping a partner or parent

Many readers of this guide are not the least confident person in their household. You may be reading it because a partner, a parent in their eighties or a friend is the one who worries. Helping someone else with technology is a skill of its own, and most of us are bad at it in the same predictable ways. A few principles make it go better for both of you.

Do it with them, not for them

The instinct is to take the phone and fix it. It is faster, and it teaches nothing. Instead, keep the phone in their hands and talk them through each tap — 'the grey cog, bottom right; now the word Display'. It takes three times as long and it sticks. If you must do something yourself, narrate it, then hand the phone back and ask them to do it again while you watch. A small notebook kept by the phone, with one page per task — 'How to video call Sarah', 'How to see my photos' — written in the words they used when they understood it, is worth more than any manual. Let them write it. Add a page for 'What to do if a caller says they are the bank' with the number on the card copied out.

Set the safety net up together

- **Go through Part 1's checklist** on their phone: text size, emergency contacts, Find My, updates, passcode. Make sure you (or someone) knows their Apple or Google account email, and that they know where the password is written.
- **Agree a family safe word** — Age UK's suggestion — that anyone asking for money must give. Practise it once so it does not feel odd.

- **Consider 'Family Sharing' (Apple) or 'Family Link' / a shared Google account**, which let you see the phone's location and help with settings from your own device. Only with their agreement: it is their phone.
- **Turn on payment notifications** on their banking app, and if they are happy with it, ask their bank whether a trusted-person or 'carer's card' arrangement is available.
- **Add the 'Who to call' table** to their notebook and to the fridge.

Patience, and when it is more than tech

Nobody learns while feeling stupid. Sighs, 'I showed you this last week' and grabbing the phone all switch learning off. If you notice yourself getting short, stop, make a cup of tea, and come back to it another day. One thing per visit is plenty. And ask them to teach you something back — a recipe, a card game, the name of that bird — so the relationship stays two-way.

If someone you care about seems to be receiving a lot of calls, getting secretive about money, or has a new online 'friend' who needs help, tread gently. Shame is what keeps people from telling. Say that anyone can be caught, that you are not angry, and offer to ring the bank together. Age UK's advice line and local Age UK offices, and AARP's helpline in the US, are there for the person supporting a victim as well as the victim.

Part 7: The 4-week plan

Twenty-eight days, one fifteen-minute task each, in a sensible order: set the phone up, lock the accounts, learn the scams, then enjoy the good stuff. Do them on your own phone, with a cup of tea. If a task takes five minutes, stop at five. If one defeats you, tick 'tried', move on, and come back to it on a spare day — there are two rest days each week for exactly that. Tick the box and write a word about how it felt; that column is where confidence shows up.

Week 1 — Make the phone yours

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 1	Find the Settings app and its search box. Search 'text size' and make the text bigger until it is comfortable.	☐
Day 2	Set up emergency contacts and medical information (Medical ID on iPhone; Safety & emergency on Android). Turn on 'show on lock screen'.	☐
Day 3	Turn on Find My (iPhone) or Find My Device / Find Hub (Android). Write down your Apple or Google account email.	☐
Day 4	Turn on automatic updates. If an update is waiting, install it while the phone charges tonight.	☐
Day 5	Check your passcode is six digits and not guessable. Set up face or fingerprint unlock if you haven't.	☐
Day 6	Explore Accessibility for ten minutes. Try one thing: bold text, magnifier, captions or hearing-aid pairing.	☐
Day 7	Rest day, or catch up. Look at the 'Settings to change today' checklist and tick what's done.	☐

Week 2 — Lock the doors

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 8	Change your email password to three random words that you use nowhere else. Write it in a safe place at home.	☐
Day 9	Turn on two-step verification for your email. Save or print the backup codes.	☐
Day 10	Turn on two-step verification for your Apple or Google account.	☐
Day 11	Find your phone's built-in password manager. Log into one website and, when it offers to save the password, say yes.	☐
Day 12	Open your banking app (or download it from the official store). Turn on payment notifications. Find the 'freeze card' switch.	☐
Day 13	Read the 'one rule about codes' callout aloud to someone. Tell them you will never read a code to a caller.	☐
Day 14	Rest day, or catch up on any Week 2 task that fought	☐

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
	back.	

Week 3 — Know the scripts

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 15	Read the scam red flags table. Photograph it or print it and put it by the phone.	☐
Day 16	Open your email. Find one message that looks a bit off. Tap the sender's name to see the real address. Delete it, or forward it to report@phishing.gov.uk.	☐
Day 17	Save 159 in your contacts as 'BANK — real number' (UK), or save the number from the back of your card. Practise saying 'I'll call you back' out loud.	☐
Day 18	Agree a family safe word with your children or closest relatives. Text it to them (then delete the text).	☐
Day 19	Forward one spam text to 7726. Then block the number.	☐
Day 20	Copy the 'Who to call' table into a notebook or onto the fridge. Add your bank's number from your card.	☐
Day 21	Rest day. Tell one person one scam script you learned this week — teaching it is the best way to remember it.	☐

Week 4 — Enjoy it

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 22	Make a ten-minute test video call with a willing family member. Find mute, camera-flip and hang-up.	☐
Day 23	Turn on photo backup and check it has completed. Delete twenty photos you do not need.	☐
Day 24	Share one photo with someone using the share button. Try a shared album if you feel brave.	☐
Day 25	Open the maps app. Ask it, by voice, for directions to somewhere you know. Follow them there on foot if you can.	☐
Day 26	Install one app from the 'useful apps' table — the library app, the NHS App or a patient portal, or a transport app — and sign in.	☐
Day 27	Ask your voice assistant to set a timer, tell you the weather and ring someone. Notice which one you will actually use.	☐
Day 28	Read back through the four weeks of 'how did it feel' notes. Write one sentence about what you can do now that you couldn't on Day 1.	☐

Jargon glossary

Word	What it actually means
App	A programme on your phone. Short for 'application'. The icons on your screen are apps.
App Store / Google Play	The official shops for apps on iPhone and Android. The only safe places to get them.
Apple ID / Google account	The master account that your phone, its backup, its app store and its Find My feature all hang off. Its password is the most important one you have after your email.
Backup	An automatic copy of your photos, contacts and settings kept on the maker's computers, so a lost phone can be restored.
Browser	The app you use to look at websites: Safari on iPhone, Chrome on Android.
The cloud	Somebody else's computers, reached over the internet. 'Saved to the cloud' means 'saved on Apple's or Google's servers, not just on this phone'.
Cookie	A small note a website leaves in your browser so it remembers you. The 'accept cookies' banners are mostly harmless nagging; 'reject all' or 'necessary only' is fine to press.
Data (mobile data)	The internet delivered by your phone network rather than by Wi-Fi. Your plan gives you a monthly allowance.
Encryption	Scrambling information so only the intended recipient can read it. 'End-to-end encrypted' messaging (like WhatsApp or iMessage) means even the company cannot read your messages.
Phishing	A fake message pretending to be from a real organisation, designed to make you click a link or hand over details. Pronounced 'fishing'.
Pop-up	A box that appears over a web page. Some are harmless (cookie notices); the alarming ones with phone numbers are scams.
QR code	A square barcode you point your camera at to open a link or menu. Safe from a restaurant table; treat one stuck over a parking meter or sent in a message with suspicion.
Remote access	Letting someone control your computer over the internet. Legitimate when you arrange it with a firm you chose; the goal of every tech-support scam otherwise.
Spoofing	Faking the number or name a call or message appears to come from. Why the caller ID on your screen proves nothing.
Two-step verification (2SV / 2FA / MFA)	A second check when you log in — usually a code sent to your phone — so a stolen password alone is not enough.
Update	A new version of your phone's software or an app, usually fixing security holes. Say yes.
Wi-Fi	The wireless internet in your home, a café or a hotel. Free to use once connected, but public Wi-Fi is not the place for banking.
Wallet (digital)	An app holding a copy of your bank card, tickets and passes so you can tap the phone to pay. Does not reveal your card number to the shop.

Finishing, and what next

If you have worked through the four weeks, take stock. Your phone is set up for your eyes and your hands. Your accounts have two locks on the door. You can name the levers a scammer pulls, and you know the one move that beats all of them. You have made a video call, backed up your photos and found your way somewhere by asking a phone out loud. None of that required expertise. It required a method and a little time, which is all it ever requires.

Keeping it going

- **Once a month:** check that photo backup is up to date, install any waiting updates, and glance at the red flags table.
- **Once a year:** change your email password, check the emergency contacts are still right, and confirm the phone still receives updates.
- **Every time:** pause, break the contact, check by a route you trust, tell someone. The rule does not wear out.
- **One new thing a month.** An app from the table, a feature in Accessibility, a voice command. Fifteen minutes. Confidence is a habit, not a state.

Tech Confident is one part of what we do at dontdieretired.com. If it has been useful, two things will help you keep going:

- **The newsletter** — a short, useful email each week with one idea, one thing to try and one honest piece of evidence, including the scam scripts doing the rounds this month. Sign up at dontdieretired.com/newsletter.
- **The members' circle** — a friendly group of readers who share what they have got working, ask the questions they were embarrassed to ask, and warn each other about the latest nonsense in their inboxes. Details at dontdieretired.com/circle.

One last thing

You were never bad with technology. You were handed a device with the important settings hidden and a stream of messages designed to worry you. Now the settings are where you want them and the messages have lost their power.

Keep the phone in your hand and the rule in your head. You have got this.

Tech Confident is a publication of dontdieretired.com. It offers general information about using phones and online services safely. App and settings names change with updates, so menus may differ slightly on your device. If you think you have been scammed, contact your bank immediately and report it: in the UK to Report Fraud (reportfraud.police.uk, 0300 123 2040) or by dialling 159 to reach your bank; in the US to the FTC at ReportFraud.ftc.gov. This guide is not financial advice; a regulated adviser can look at your own situation.